

Evidentiality in Kurmanji
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1. Introduction

This chapter examines evidentiality in Kurmanji, an Iranian language spoken primarily in Türkiye and Syria, focusing on the Adıyaman dialect. It discusses (i) evidential strategies in Kurmanji, (ii) the morphosyntactic mechanisms used to encode information source, (iii) the associated semantic properties and contexts of use, including dreams, amnesia, folktales, and inference, and (iv) an analysis of the core components underlying perfect, evidential, and mirative constructions in the language.

Much of the description aligns with Bulut (2000), who argues that the perfect form is used in evidential contexts. We depart from Bulut in one key respect: Bulut claims that the perfect forms alone is insufficient to encode evidentiality in Kurmanji and must be accompanied by an additional element, typically an adverb. In contrast, we show that the perfect form by itself can yield an evidential interpretation. We then proceed by proposing an analysis of Kurmanji evidentials based on the syncretism of perfect, evidential, and mirative meanings, following Lau & Rooryck (2017).

The chapter is organized as follows. Section 2 provides a brief introduction to evidentiality and presents a Kurmanji example that is four-way ambiguous between perfect, reported, inferential, or mirative readings. Section 3 outlines the morphosyntactic structure of verbal and non-verbal clauses with evidential morphology. Section 4 discusses core semantic properties of perfect, evidential, and mirative constructions in Kurmanji. Section 5 illustrates various contexts of Kurmanji evidential use, with particular attention to dreams, amnesia, and storytelling. Section 6 offers a compositional analysis of evidential, mirative, and perfect clauses, and Section 7 concludes the chapter.

2. Evidentiality, Mirativity, and Perfect

Evidentiality encodes source of information (Aikhenvald 2004, 2015). Information sources may be direct, where the speaker has first-hand knowledge through observation, or indirect, where the speaker relies on report or inference (Willett 1998). The Quechua examples in (1) illustrate these distinctions: the suffix *-mi* marks direct evidence, *-si* encodes hearsay, and *-chá* marks inference.

- (1) Quechua (Faller 2002, p. 170)
- a. Para-sha-n-**mi**.
Rain-prog-3-mi
p = ‘It is raining.’
EV = speaker sees that *p*

- b. Para-sha-n-si.
rain-prog-3-si
p = 'It is raining.'
EV = speaker was told that *p*
- c. Para-sha-n-**chá**.
rain-prog-3-chá
p = 'It is raining.'
EV = speaker conjectures that *p*

Languages differ in how they encode source of information in a clause. While some languages develop dedicated grammatical forms for encoding the source of information as in Quechua, others capitalize on existing forms to encode the source of information. Turkish exemplifies the latter pattern: evidential distinctions are integrated into the tense–aspect system. Aksu-Koç and Slobin (1986) argue that the past tense suffix *-DI* encodes direct evidence, whereas the perfect marker *-miş* encodes indirect evidence, including both hearsay and inference, as illustrated in (2)–(5).¹

- (2) Deniz okul-a git-ti.
Deniz school-DAT go-PAST
'Deniz went to school.' (The speaker has direct evidence, e.g. saw it happen.)
- (3) Deniz okul-a git-miş. Anne-si öyle söyle-di.
Deniz school-DAT go-PERF.EVID mother-GEN so tell-PAST
'Deniz went to school. Her mother said so.'
- (4) Bardağ-ım çatla-mış.
cup-GEN.1SG crack-PERF.EVID
'My cup cracked.' (I just realized)
- (5) Hırsız bura-dan kaçmış. Öyle anlaşıl-ıyor.
thief here-ABL escape-PERF.EVID so understand-IMPF
'The thief escaped through here. That's how it looks.'

The syncretism between perfect morphology and evidentiality is a common crosslinguistic fact observed in many languages including Turkish, Norwegian, Bulgarian, and Georgian among others (Izvorski 1997, Lau & Rooryck 2017, Aikenwald 2018). The fact that this syncretism is observed across typologically unrelated languages indicates a deep connection between the two concepts and has attracted much attention in the field. Putting the details aside, the basic intuitive account is presented by Comrie (1976), who suggested that both evidentiality and perfect present an event not in itself but through its results.

¹ Traditional grammars of Turkish such as Gencan (1979), Ergin (1986), Banguoğlu (2000) typically describe *-miş* as a Past Tense marker. Lewis (1967), Underhill (1985), Kornfilt (1997), and Göksel and Kerslake (2005), on the other hand, classify it as a Perfective marker. Slobin and Aksu-Koç (1982) argue that *-miş* encompasses Tense-Aspect and Modality simultaneously.

(6) Eşxan hat-i-ye.
Eşxan come.PAST-PART-COP.PRES
PERFECT : ‘Eşxan has arrived.’
INFERENCE : ‘Apparently, Eşxan has arrived.’
REPORTED : ‘I hear that Eşxan has arrived.’
MIRATIVE : ‘Woow, Eşxan has arrived.’

3. Morphosyntax of Evidentiality in Kurmanji

(7) Ez dı-çü-m mal.
I.DIR IMPF-go.PAST-1SG home
'I was going home.'

The two clauses above differ only in terms of tense. (7) is a past habitual whereas (8) is a present habitual. We observe one difference between the examples: the verbal root alternates between *her* and *çü*, two suppletive forms that bear both verbal root and tense information.² With this information in the

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background, let us now compare a simple past tense clause with a perfect/resultative one as in (9) and (10).

- (9) M₁ şiv xar.
I.ERG food eat.PAST
'I ate food.'

- (10) M₁ şiv xar-i-ye.
I.ERG food eat.PAST-PART-COP
'I have eaten food.' (I am in the state of having eaten food.)

While (9) reports a simple past event, (10) highlights the relevance of the result of eating at the time of utterance. For instance, (10) is typically used when someone is invited to join a meal but politely declines, indicating they have already eaten. In (10), the proposition's key contribution concerns the resultant state, as shown by its compatibility with a durational construction in (11), a pattern unavailable for the simple past, as illustrated in (12).

- (11) Wa sê saat-in k₁ m₁ şiv xar-i-ye.
this three hour-COP.PL that I.ERG food eat.PAST-PART-COP
'It's been three hours since I have eaten.'
Lit: This has been three hours that I am in the state of having eaten food.

- (12) *Wa sê saat-in k₁ m₁ şiv xar.
this three hour-COP.PL that I.ERG food eat.PAST
'It's been three hours since I ate.'

Now that we have established the distinction between simple past and perfect/resultative clauses in Kurmanji, let us take a closer look at the structure of perfect/resultative verbs. The perfect/resultative verb in (10) *xar-i-ye* has two additional morphemes compared to the past verb in (11) *xar*. What is the nature of *-i* and *-ye*?

The suffix *-i* appears to function as a participial head that derives a resultant state. It occurs both in finite clauses, as in (10), and in deverbal adjectives, as in (13). Notably, in (13b), *-i* attaches to a verb bearing clausal negation, suggesting that it takes scope over negation and merges higher than head that introduces negation.

- (13) a. isot-ê dagirt-i
pepper-ezafe pickle.PAST-PART
'pickled peppers'
- b. qitık-ê ne-şuşt-i
shirt-ezafe NEG-wash.PAST-PART
'unwashed shirt'

The participial head that is realized as *-i* in perfect/resultative clauses bears agreement as well. Third person singular agreement in Kurmanji is null. Thus, we observe *-i* in configurations like (10) as the object is third person and the subject is marked with oblique case, which prevents the probes to enter agreement with the subject.³ *-i* disappears when the participial head shows overt agreement with a nominal other than 3rd person singular. This is illustrated in (14).

- (14) a. Ez çü-m-ê.
I.DIR go.PAST-1SG-COP.PRES
'I have gone.'
- b. Mî sêw xar-in-ê
I.OBL apple.PL eat.PAST-PL-COP.PRES
'I have eaten apples.'

Given that *-i* appears in (10) but not in (9), we assume that a resultative participial head is present in all perfective/resultative constructions. Regarding its merge site, it must be at least above negation, since it takes scope over it. Because tense fuses with the root, its position relative to tense is less clear. Nevertheless, we assume that it merges below T, as tense in perfect/resultative constructions appears to be realized on the copula, as discussed below.

The suffix *-ye* that appears on perfect/resultative constructions is a copula that bears tense and agreement information. It is the same copular that appears in non-verbal copular constructions illustrated in (15).

- (15) a. Mehemed nexaş-ê
Mehemed sick-COP.PRES
'Mehemed is sick.'
- b. Mehemed nexaş-(w)u
Mehemed sick.COP.PAST
'Mehemed was sick.'

Non-verbal predicates can also appear in evidential form. This is achieved by adding a second copula above the PAST form of the copula as illustrated in (16).

- (16) Mehemed nexaş-wu-ye.
Mehemed sick-COP.PAST-COP.PRES
EVIDENTIAL: 'Mehemed is sick.'

The sentence in (16) can be interpreted as a reported, inferential or mirative. What it cannot be interpreted as is the present perfect. Consider the sentence in (18), the counterpart of (16) inflected for first person,

³ Kurmanji is a split-ergative language where NPs marked with OBL case do not feed agreement whereas NPs appearing in bare form do. See Atlamaz & Baker (2018) for a detailed account of Kurmanji case and agreement facts.

which again only allows for reported, inferential or mirative readings, but not present perfect which can be expressed with a different verbal form as in (17).

- (17) Wa dı ro-ne k1 ez i nexaş-ım.
 This two day-COP.PL that I.DIR AUX sick-COP.PRES.1SG
 ‘I have been sick for two days.’
 Lit: ‘It is two days that I am sick.’

- (18) #Wa dı ro-ne k1 ez i nexaş-um-e.
 This two day-COP.PL that I.DIR AUX sick-COP.PAST.1SG-COP.PRES
 ‘I have been sick for two days.’

(17) describes a scenario where the speaker has been sick for two days. The structure does not involve any perfectivity. Under the same scenario (18) is infelicitous if the speaker is describing the fact that they have been sick for two days. The choice of the subject is intentional here. Since the subject is first person, the speaker must have first hand information about their sickness. This is why (18) is not acceptable. (18) becomes acceptable when it describes a scenario where the speaker did not have first hand information about their sickness. Consider (19) which is a similar example with a slightly different context.

- (19) Wa sê sal-in k1 ez i nexaş-um-e.
 This three year-COP.PL that I.DIR AUX sick-COP.PAST.1SG-COP.PRES
 ‘I have been sick for three years.’
- Hema mı nı-zanu. Tıxtor mı ra go
 But I.OBL NEG-know.PAST doctor I.OBL to say.PAST
 ‘But I didn’t know.’ ‘The doctor told me.’

Non-verbal evidentials in Kurmanji are instructive in several respects. First, they show that evidentiality can be expressed independently of a perfect interpretation, unlike what is often observed with verbal evidentials. Second, they challenge Bulut’s (2000) claim that evidentiality in Kurmanji is not grammaticalized and must be expressed through adverbs or other means. This is simply because (19) has no non-evidential interpretation. We argue instead that evidentiality is grammaticalized, although it lacks a dedicated affix. Rather, evidential meaning arises through syncretism with perfect/resultative morphology, which does not imply that the two are not distinct grammatical items.⁴

Given the facts above, we can describe the syntactic structure of evidentials in Kurmanji as follows. Evidentials where the main predicate is verbal are constructed by first adding the participial head realized as *-i* and then embedding it under a copula. In non-verbal predicates, *-i* is not needed. Instead, a second copula is merged above the main copula which appears in the past form.

⁴ Natural languages are rife with syncretism. One very common syncretism observed across languages is what Embick (2004) calls the U-syncretism, which is the name of a common observation where in many languages passives, reflexives, and inchoatives share the same suffix. Obviously, syncretism cannot mean that languages with U-syncretism have not developed distinct grammatical constructions for passives, reflexives, or inchoatives.

(20) Verbal Evidential
V.PAST - PART - COP

(21) Non-verbal Evidential
ADJ/NOUN - COP.PAST - COP

Why do verbal predicates require the participial *-i*, whereas non-verbal predicates do not? We propose that this follows from the compositional nature of evidentiality. Non-verbal predicates inherently denote states, while verbal predicates do not. The participial is therefore required to shift a verbal predicate into a resultant state, a key component of evidential meaning. As noted earlier, evidentials characterize an event not directly, but through its results (Comrie 1976). This accounts for the absence of *-i* in non-verbal predicates but it does not explain why non-verbal predicates need two copulas where the first one has to be in past form. We argue that being a state by itself is not a sufficient ingredient for evidentials. It has to be a resultant state. The past form of the copula is needed to indicate that the state is a resultant state.

Now that we described the morphosyntactic properties of perfect/resultative constructions and evidentials in Kurmanji, in the next section, we turn to the semantic properties of evidentials and the various contexts in which they occur.

4. Semantic Properties of Evidentials in Kurmanji

In Kurmanji, the main contribution of evidentiality is indirect evidence. The source of information can be a report. There is no distinction between second hand, third hand or general hearsay. They are all covered by the same form. The examples in (22)-(23) illustrate reported evidentials.

(22) Mı bist kî Mehemed hat-i-ye.
I.OBL heard that Meheemd come.PAST-PART-COP.PRES
'I heard that Mehemed arrived.'

(23) A: Ka Mehemed?
where Mehemed
'Where is Mehemed?'

B: Çü-ø-ye çarşıye.
go.PAST-PART-COP.PRES marketplace
'He went to the marketplace/downtown.' (I heard)

A: Kê go?
Who say.PAST
'Who said that?'

B: Eşxan-ê go.
Eşxan-OBL say.PAST
'Eşxan said.'

In addition to describing reported information, Kurmanji evidentials can also be used for inference. Instances of inference are illustrated in (24)-(25).

(24) **Context:**

Eşxan walks into the room. The floor is wet. There is a cat in the room and an empty cup.

Eşxan says

Pîsîk-e aw welot-i-ye.
cat-OBL water spill.PAST-PART-COP.PRES
'The cat spilt the water.'

(25) **Context:**

Eşxan walks into the room. The window is open and the TV is missing.

Eşxan says

Dîz-a telûzon bîr-in-e.
thief-OBL.PL TV take.PAST-PART.PL-COP.PRES
'The thieves took the TV.'

In (24) and (25) the information is gained through inference. Simple past is not appropriate in these contexts and the evidential form has to be used.

In addition to reports and inference, evidential morphology in Kurmanji is also used as a mirative. Mirativity is defined as expressing surprise or a sudden realization (Jacobsen 1964, Slobin & Aksu 1982, DeLancey 1997, Aikhenvald 2012). The following examples illustrate the mirative use of evidentials in Kurmanji.

(26) **Context:**

Eşxan is looking for her shirt in the closet. When she finds the shirt, she notices a small tear in the shirt.

Eşxan exclaims:

Pey wa qet-i-ye.
Wow this tear.PAST-PART-COP.PRES
'Wow, this is torn.'

(27) **Context:**

Mehemed asks Eşxan if she has seen the kids. Eşxan says she doesn't know where they are. They get a little worried and start looking around the house. When Eşxan opens the garden door, she sees that the kids are playing in the garden. She comes back and says:

Eşxan says:

Kırîk lî bexçê dî-lîz-uw-in-e
child.PL at garden IMPF-play-COP.PAST-PL-COP.PRES
'Children have been playing in the garden.'

Mirativity is usually described as a sudden realization. Lau and Rooryck (2017) define it as a “as a punctual transition from the epistemic state of ignorance to that of awareness”. This punctual transition between epistemic states suggests that the interpretation is sudden. However, Kurmanji evidentials can express this shift in epistemic states without necessarily implying a sudden shift. The crucial point seems to be a shift between epistemic states. This is illustrated in the following conversation.

(28) **Kurmanji Conversation**

We re ez çüm male Zelxe. E çüm kî Zelx dîgriye. Mî go “çîr bu?” Go wo se carîn kî Mehemed-e gotiye ez e werim hema natiye. Ez jî pera qarim. Mî telfune kîr a pera qariya. Mî go tî çîma hîngo dîke. Wa jînkî tîm lî te gîdar dîke. Ne eybe? Paşê jî em poşman bûnî. *Mehemed i nexaş-wu-ye.* Qe me nîzawu. Me poşê hu kîr.

English

That day, I went to Zelxe’s place. When I got there, I saw that Zelx was crying. I said “What happened?” She said it was the third time Mehemed promised to visit but he did not. I got mad at him. I called and yelled at him. I said, “Why are you acting like this?” This woman is always waiting. Isn’t it a shame? Later, we regretted it. Apparently Mehemed was sick. But we didn’t know. We learnt it later.

- (29) Mehemed i nexaş-wu-ye
Mehemed AUX sick-COP.PAST-COP.PRES
‘It turned out Mehemed was sick.’

The italicized sentence in the Kurmanji conversation in (28), glossed in (29), indicates a change in the epistemic state of the speaker from the state of ignorance to that of awareness. The nature of the change is rather underspecified. We do not know if it was a sudden realization or a gradual understanding of the situation over an extended period. We also do not know if the information was acquired through inference, report or direct observation (e.g. the speaker sees Mehemed’s health in poor condition). Thus, the core meaning associated with this use of evidentiality seems to be a shift in the epistemic state of the speaker (not necessarily a sudden one). We take this to be “realization” and categorize under mirativity adopting Aikhenvald’s (2012) definition of mirativity.

So far, we have shown that the evidentials in Kurmanji mainly contribute one of the three meanings, reported and inferential evidence as well as mirativity. We took the key component in mirativity to be an epistemic shift from a state of ignorance to that of awareness. In other words, mirativity in Kurmanji is a matter of realizing some information after the fact. In the next section, we describe some contexts in which these core meanings of reported, inferential, and realizational (mirative) evidentiality are used.

5. Evidentiality across various contexts

Given that evidentiality describes information source in general and the various ways in which the information is gained, we see its use in a wide range of contexts. One interesting context where evidentials are used in Kurmanji is the reporting of a dream. When describing a dream, speakers usually start with an evidential statement to set the stage. The following excerpt illustrates the use of evidentials in the dream context.

(30) **Eşxan is describing a dream she had the night before**

Dhuni mı xewnik di. *Em çün-e malê api mi. Şênik pır hat-i-ye.* Xara millet dil dıkine. E deme pey wa çı şênıye? Dene pısmamê te dıke bızevce. Wo ji dhovete. A, mı kef kır. Ez ketım orte o mı ji dil kır...

English translation

Yesterday, I had a dream. We went to my uncle's. A big crowd has gathered. People are just dancing. I say "What is this crowd?" They say, your cousin is getting married. This is her wedding. Oh, I was very happy. I got in the middle and danced...

In (30), the two italicized sentences appear in evidential form. These are the first two sentences that describe the setting of the dream. Their primary contribution is mirative: they convey the speaker's realization upon finding herself in the dream. Specifically, she recognizes that the place is her uncle's and that many people gathered there. Once the setting is established, the remainder of the dream is expressed without evidentials, indicating that the speaker treats the subsequent events as first-hand information.

A second context where evidentials are used is the context of amnesia. When a speaker describes their own actions that they do not remember due to some amnesia, they usually use evidentials. Consider the following example:

(31) **Eşxan is describing an accident she was involved**

Wê rê mı pisiklet dıvır ser sılımə. Nigê mı xışıyo u ez ketım. Paşê, mı çawê xa wekır ki ez i lı xestême. *Embulas hat-i-ye. Ez bır-ım-e xestê. Tıxtor hat-i-ye. Pulis hat-ın-e kî ka wa çito bu.* Hema tı tişt neye bire mı....

English translation

That day, I was taking the bike on the stairs. My leg slipped and I fell down. Later, I opened my eyes to see that I am at the hospital. *An ambulance came. It took me to the hospital. The doctor came. The police arrived to figure out how this happened.* But I remember none of it. ...

In (31), the italicized sentences use evidentials. This is the part when the speaker had amnesia and they do not remember the events but they were told about what happened.

A third context where evidentials are widely used is the storytelling scenarios, especially if this is a story learnt by the speaker through hearsay. This is illustrated in the following example with the evidential expressions marked in italics. The main contribution of the evidential is reported information. The speaker did not observe the event directly and they are reciting a story they learnt from someone else.

(32) **Eşxan is telling a story she learnt during her childhood**

Wextikê zemanikê, *jınıkık he-vu-ye.* Nawî xa *Melek-wu-ye.* Ra kê Melek pır *birçi buye.* Çüye mala xa ki hevık nê nê bixe...

English translation

Once upon a time, there was a woman. Her name was Melek. One day Melek was very hungry. She went home to eat something....

6. An analysis of Kurmanji Evidentials

So far, we have shown that evidentials in Kurmanji share their morphology with perfect/resultative constructions. The range of meanings associated with evidentiality in Kurmanji includes inference, report, and mirativity, and evidentials occur across a wide range of contexts, including dream narratives, amnesia, and storytelling. Bulut (2000) provides a detailed description of Kurmanji evidentials, arguing that evidentiality is not yet grammaticalized and instead requires additional elements such as adverbs or embedding predicates. On this view, the use of perfect morphology reflects a compatibility between evidential and perfect meanings.

However, we have shown that non-verbal predicates can also appear in evidential constructions without any perfect interpretation. This suggests that evidentiality in Kurmanji is in fact grammaticalized and can be expressed independently of perfect meaning. This raises the following questions: (i) what is the shared core of evidentiality, mirativity, and perfect/resultative constructions in Kurmanji that gives rise to their syncretism? and (ii) what is the nature of non-verbal evidentials, formed by the combination of a past copula with a second copula, which may be either past or present?

Syncretism between perfect and evidential morphology has long been observed. Early accounts propose that both constructions involve accessing an event through its results (Comrie 1976; Bybee and Dahl 1989), a longstanding intuition. More recent approaches analyze evidentials as epistemic modals with a shared core of exclusion. In particular, Izvorski (1997) argues that both evidentials and the perfect involve exclusion: either of the event time from the utterance time, or of the set of worlds in which the proposition holds from the speaker's epistemic world. Other notable contributions to the analysis of perfect–evidential syncretism include Chung (2007), Speas (2010), Koev (2011), and Şener (2011). However, while these accounts capture the relationship between evidentiality and the perfect, they do not straightforwardly extend to mirative meanings.

To account for the syncretism among miratives, inference, report, and perfect constructions, Lau and Rooryck (2017) propose an alternative approach in which the common core involves reference to a shift between stages, grounded in Vendler's (1967) aspectual classes. They argue that Vendlerian classes (states, processes, accomplishments, and achievements) are defined in terms of stages. These are illustrated in (33).

- (33)
- | | |
|--------------------|---|
| a. States | : < S > |
| b. Processes | : < S _i , S _n , S _{n+1} > |
| c. Accomplishments | : < S _i , S _n , S _{n+1} , S _f > |
| d. Achievements | : < S _i , S _f > |

States consist of a single *stage* < S >. Processes consist of an initial stage S_i plus some subsequent stages with no natural final stage (i.e. no telicity). Accomplishments have an initial stage S_i and a final stage S_f with some intermediate stages. Finally, achievements have an initial and a final stage with no intermediate

stages. In Lau and Rooryck's system, the initial and final stages S_i and S_f have a special ontological status. Morphological aspect operates on these stages whereby inchoatives highlight S_i , progressive highlights the transitions between intermediate stages (i.e. processes). Crucially, perfect highlights that all stages are completed before the utterance time (UT) and the final stage holds at the utterance time. Formally, Lau and Rooryck define present perfect as follows:

- (34) *Perfect*
 $s = \{s \mid \langle s_i, \dots, s_f \rangle \subset S\}$
 $\lambda s. \lambda e (s < UT) \text{ and } s_f \text{ holds at UT}$ (Lau and Rooryck 2017, p. 8)

Lau and Rooryck argue that the common core of the perfect, evidentials, and mirativity lies in the notion that “all stages of some X occur prior to the utterance time, with the final stage S_f holding at the utterance time.” In the case of the perfect, X corresponds to the stages of an event. In the case of evidentials and mirativity, X instead comprises the speaker's information states, with the speaker transitioning from one epistemic stage to the next. This is formalized in (35).

- (35) *Indirect Evidentiality*
 $i_u = \text{information update}$
 $s_{IE} = \{s \mid \langle s_i, \dots, s_f \rangle \subset S\}$
 $\lambda s. \lambda i_u (s < UT) \text{ and } s_f \text{ holds at UT}$ (Lau and Rooryck 2017, p. 9)

In this model, evidentiality and mirativity are both analyzed as interpretations in which the speaker's epistemic state is updated prior to the utterance time, with the final state holding at the utterance time. Inference and hearsay involve cases where intermediate stages occur between the initial and final stages, aligning them with accomplishments, whereas mirativity (sudden realization) arises when no intermediate stage is present, aligning it with achievements. The common core of perfect, evidential, and mirative constructions is thus an underspecified representation in which stages are structurally defined, but their content (whether eventive or epistemic) remains unspecified.

- (36) *Present perfect / indirect evidentiality / mirativity*
 $s = \{s \mid \langle s_i, \dots, s_f \rangle \subset S\}$
 $\lambda s (s < UT) \text{ and } s_f \text{ holds at UT}$ (Lau and Rooryck 2017, p. 12)

Following Lau and Rooryck, we assume that the common core of evidentials, miratives, and perfect constructions is the meaning in (36). We further argue that this meaning is compositional, consisting of two key components: (i) $s < UT$, which encodes that all stages of the event or information update occur prior to the utterance time, and (ii) s_f holds at UT, which indicates that the final stage holds at the utterance time.

We propose that these components may be realized either within a single morpheme, as in Turkish *-mİş*, or distributed across distinct morphemes, as in Kurmanji. In verbal perfects and evidentials, “ $s < UT$ ” is encoded by the past verbal stem, while “ s_f holds at UT” is encoded by the present tense copula. Consider the example in (37).

- (37) *hat - i - ye*
 come.PAST-PART-COP.PRES
 ‘s/he has come.’ (ambiguous between perfect and evidential)

Abstracting away from the contributions of the verbal root, aspect, and information updates, the relevant contribution of past marking on the verbal stem *hat* ‘came’ is to order all stages of the event or information update prior to the utterance time. The present copula *-ye*, in turn, contributes that the final stage of the event or information update holds at the utterance time. These contributions are schematically represented in (38).

- (38) $\text{hat} = \lambda s (s < \text{UT})$
 $-\text{ye} = s_f \text{ holds at UT}$

One question remains: what is the contribution of *-i*? We propose that the copula requires access to a state, specifically the final stage. In Kurmanji, *-i* serves to extract the final resultant state from the set of stages introduced by the past stem. As noted in Section 2, *-i* also appears in deverbal adjectives, where it encodes a resultant state. This analysis accounts for the syncretism among perfect, evidential, and mirative constructions in Kurmanji, and clarifies the role of each morpheme in deriving verbal perfective, evidential, and mirative meanings.⁵

We now turn to non-verbal evidentials. These differ from verbal evidentials and miratives in two key respects: they do not yield a perfect interpretation, and they do not combine with *-i*. We argue that both properties follow from the model proposed above. Non-verbal predicates, as in (17)–(19), repeated below as (19') for convenience, inherently denote states; as predicted by the model and noted by Lau and Rooryck, states do not form perfects.

- (19') *Wa sê sal-in kî ez î nexaş-um-e.*
 This three year-COP.PL that I.DIR AUX sick-COP.PAST.1SG-COP.PRES
 ‘I have been sick for three years.’

- (39) * This inscription has been in Latin (Lau & Rooryck 2017, p. 9)

Stative predicates consist of a single stage, $\langle S \rangle$, with no distinct initial or final stage. This explains why they cannot appear in perfect constructions, and why perfects of non-verbal predicates are not allowed in Kurmanji. In contrast, the speaker’s epistemic state regarding a stative predicate can change, generating multiple stages, including a final stage (i.e., the state of awareness). Consequently, when a second copula is added to a non-verbal predicate, it can only yield an evidential or mirative interpretation.

Why do verbal evidentials require the participial suffix *-i*, while non-verbal evidentials disallow it? As noted above, *-i* takes a set of stages as input and returns the final stage as the resultant state. Non-verbal

⁵ The next logical step is to provide a fully compositional analysis of how each meaning is derived. However, we leave this for future research.

predicates, being inherently single-stage states, neither require nor permit *-i*. In these predicates, the lower copula must appear in the past, while the higher copula may be present or past. We propose that the lower copula satisfies the first condition of evidentiality/mirativity, “ $s < UT$ ”, and the higher copula directly accesses the sole stage of the state, indicating that it holds at the utterance time. This mechanism allows evidentiality to be expressed with non-verbal predicates in Kurmanji.⁶

7. Conclusion

This chapter has examined the expression of evidentiality in Kurmanji, highlighting both verbal and non-verbal constructions. We have shown that Kurmanji evidentials use a syncretic form between perfects, indirect evidentials, and miratives. Verbal evidentials involve the combination of a past stem, a participial suffix *-i*, and a (present) copula *-ye*, where the past stem encodes that all stages of the event or information update precede the utterance time and the copula signals that the final stage holds at the utterance time. The participial *-i* extracts the resultant state from as the final stage of the set of stages denoted by the past stem. This explains why *-i* is required in verbal predicates but disallowed in non-verbal predicates, which are inherently single-stage predicates (i.e. states). Non-verbal evidentials instead employ a double copula construction, where the lower copula must be in past form but the higher copula can be in past or present form. The lower copula satisfies the requirement that all the stages must be before the utterance time and the higher copula ensures that the final stage holds at the utterance time (or the reference time if the higher copula is also past).

We have also argued that the common semantic core of perfects, evidentials, and miratives can be understood in terms of stage-based representations, following Lau and Rooryck (2017). In aspect, stages correspond to event phases; in evidentials and miratives, stages correspond to the speaker’s epistemic states. This compositional, stage-based approach captures the systematicity of syncretism while allowing for differences between verbal and non-verbal constructions.

Finally, our analysis has shown that Kurmanji evidentials are grammaticalized and contextually versatile, occurring in narratives, dream reports, amnesia contexts, and everyday storytelling. This highlights the central role of epistemic shifts in understanding evidentiality and mirativity, and situates Kurmanji within cross-linguistic patterns linking perfect, evidential, and mirative meanings.

A natural next step is to develop a fully compositional analysis of perfect and evidential clauses in Kurmanji, specifying the syntactic position of each component and deriving their semantics compositionally. We leave this for future work.

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⁶ It should be noted that in Kurmanji, the higher copula can also be past tense which gives rise to either past perfect or an evidential/mirative regarding a past reference. Given this, we believe that the denotation of perfect/evidential/mirative should be updated to capture a reference time (RT) rather than the utterance time (UT). We believe this is trivial.

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